

HOLD THE LINE PM Modi with leader of the Opposition in the assembly Suvendu Adhikari (right) and other leaders at a rally in Kolkata, Mar. 14

ONWARDS AND UPWARDS

The BJP has a controlled and state-specific strategy, whether it is Bengal's fine-tuned poll machine, Assam's leader-driven model, or the progressive wins in the south

↘ West Bengal: The BJP is running a 'quieter' campaign, using the Sangh network for the Hindutva rhetoric, while playing up TMC's law and order lapses. The 'boost' from ECI will not hurt

↘ Assam: CM Sarma's personal network and credibility makes him the face of the campaign. He's neutralised the Muslim vote and has firmed up alliances, could deliver a decisive mandate

↘ Tamil Nadu: The BJP is back in alliance with the AIADMK after realising that going solo boosted voteshare but with zero returns in seats. Incremental progress for now

↘ Kerala: A first ever LS seat in 2024 has boosted confidence. Eyeing 10-15 seats with high-profile candidates, but lack of organisational depth may be a damper

↘ Puducherry: Six seats in 2021, also part of AINRC-led government. Now the BJP is the other major alliance partner, relegating the AIADMK to a minor role

way to broaden the party's appeal. Internal assessments suggest that even a 4-6 per cent fragmentation within the minority vote can be decisive in 40-50 constituencies.

That said, the BJP is also relying on the Sangh's grassroots networks to amplify the narratives around alleged violence against Hindus in Bangladesh, concerns over demographic shifts, illegal infiltration, and perceived local security threats. Late last year, the Sangh and their affiliates had already ramped up the door-to-door outreach programmes in the state. Insiders say some 94,000 local 'mohalla meetings' have been organised across Bengal in the past few months. The Sangh's centenary programme, Ghar Ghar Sampark Abhiyan, provided the perfect occasion, with RSS swayamsevaks putting every effort into covering the Dalit and Adivasi-concentrated blocks. Massive Ramnavami mobilisation, reportedly across some 1,000 locations in Bengal, was all part of the pre-election drum roll.

The Sangh network, too, has grown. Sources say that in south Bengal alone, the number of RSS shakhas has doubled to some 12,000 right now. Motivation levels are high, they say, buoyed by the visits of "high-level leaders". RSS sarsanghchalak Mohan Bhagwat was in Bengal on a 10-day visit in February.